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HER STORY, REWRITTEN: VOLUME TWO



*Eight more women of the Bible, the moment everything turned,
and what their courage is still saying to yours.*

BY MK PARRISH • \$24

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN, AGAIN

If you read the first volume of this book, you already know the promise, and you can skip ahead to meet the women. But some of you are starting here, so let me say it once more, because it is the whole reason these pages exist.

Every woman in this book was a real person before she was a lesson.

The world remembers a handful of them as heroines and forgets the rest entirely, and both of those are ways of not really seeing them. Because the truth is that most of these women turned up in the story at an ordinary, difficult, frightened moment — a moment a lot like the one you might be in right now — and did one brave or faithful or stubborn thing, and it changed everything downstream, usually without their knowing it would.

The first volume was mostly women who were seen at the bottom of the page. This volume leans into something a little different: women who *acted*. Who led armies and cut through arguments and reached through a crowd and refused to be talked out of what they knew. If the first book was about being found, this one is about what you do once you have been.

You still do not need to know your Bible to read this. You need to be a woman who suspects she is braver than she has been given permission to be. That, it turns out, describes almost every woman in Scripture — and, I suspect, you.

Come meet them.

DEBORAH — THE WOMAN WHO WAS ALREADY IN CHARGE

Before there were kings in Israel, there were judges — leaders who settled disputes and led the people — and one of them was a woman named Deborah, and the Bible does not make a single apology for it.

That is the first thing worth noticing. In a time and place where women were not supposed to hold that kind of authority, Deborah simply *did*. She sat under a palm tree, and the whole nation came to her to have their hardest questions answered, and nobody in the text stops to explain it or defend it. She was wise, and so she led. It was as plain as that.

When the army needed to march against a brutal oppressor, the general — a man named Barak — flatly refused to go unless Deborah came with him. Think about that. The commander of the army would not move without the woman leading beside him. And Deborah went. She told him the truth, too: because you are doing it this way, she said, the final honor of the victory will go to a woman, not to you. And it did — another woman entirely finished the battle.

Deborah is in this book for the woman who has been waiting for someone to *give* her authority she has, in fact, held all along. Who keeps hoping to be picked, appointed, permitted. Deborah did not wait for permission. She saw what needed doing and the wisdom she had to do it, and she sat down under the tree and started answering the questions. The people came because she was worth coming to.

You may be waiting for a title that is never going to arrive. Deborah's story says: lead from where you already are. The palm tree was not a throne. She made it one by being the person people could trust under it.

RAHAB — THE OUTSIDER WHO BET ON MERCY

Rahab had two strikes against her by the standards of her world: she was a foreigner, and she was a woman with a disreputable trade. She lived in the wall of a city that was about to be destroyed, and she had every reason to expect nothing good from anyone.

When two spies came through, hunted and in danger, Rahab made a choice that made no earthly sense. She hid them. She risked her life to protect people from a nation that was, by all accounts, her enemy — because she had heard the stories of what their God had done, and something in her decided to bet everything on that God being real and merciful. She asked one thing in return: when the city falls, remember me. Remember my family. Show us the mercy I am showing you.

And they did. When the walls came down, the one house left standing was the one with the outsider's family inside it.

Here is what almost nobody tells you about Rahab. She does not disappear after that. She marries into the people of Israel. And generations later, when the family tree of the Messiah is written down, her name is in it — the foreign woman with the shameful reputation, listed without embarrassment among the ancestors of Christ.

Rahab is here for anyone who thinks their history has locked them out of the good story. The woman who assumes that where she comes from, or what she has done, has quietly disqualified her from ever belonging to something holy. Rahab bet her whole life on the idea that mercy was bigger than her past. She was right. The bet paid off for a thousand years.

Your past is not the last word on your future. Ask the woman in the wall. Ask the outsider they wrote into the lineage of God.

ABIGAIL — THE WOMAN WHO WALKED INTO THE STORM

Abigail was married to a wealthy fool. The Bible is unusually blunt about it: her husband, Nabal, was harsh and mean, and his name literally meant *fool*. He insulted the wrong man — a future king named David — and David, hot with wounded pride, gathered four hundred armed men to wipe out Nabal's entire household in revenge.

Nobody told Nabal. Nobody could reason with him. So the only person standing between an entire household and a massacre was Abigail — and she did not hesitate.

She loaded up food and supplies, rode out to meet an approaching army by herself, and got down off her donkey in front of a furious warlord. And then she did something extraordinary: she talked him down. Not by groveling. By being the wisest, clearest voice in a situation full of pride and rage. She took responsibility that was not hers to take, she appealed to the better version of the man in front of her, and she gently, brilliantly reminded David of who he wanted to become. *One day you will be glad,* she told him, *that you did not have this blood on your hands.*

David stopped the attack. He blessed her for her good sense. *Blessed is your judgment,* he said, *and blessed are you, who kept me from doing this.*

Abigail is in this book for the woman who is the only steady person in a situation full of other people's foolishness and fury. The one who has to be the adult, again, and defuse what she did not detonate. It is exhausting, unfair work. But Abigail shows what it can be at its best: not martyrdom, but *wisdom in motion* — the clear voice that walks straight into the storm and changes the ending.

Sometimes the bravest thing in the room is a calm woman who refuses to let the fools decide how the story goes.

THE WOMAN WHO REACHED THROUGH THE CROWD

For twelve years she had been bleeding, and in her world that did not just make her sick — it made her *untouchable*. By the rules of the day, her condition meant she could not be touched, could not worship in the usual way, could not live a normal life. Twelve years of that. She had spent every coin she had on doctors who could not help and only left her poorer and more alone.

She heard that a healer named Jesus was passing through, surrounded by a crushing crowd. And she made a decision that took more nerve than anyone watching could have understood. She, the untouchable one, pushed *into* the crowd she was forbidden to be in, and she thought: if I can just touch the edge of his clothes, that will be enough.

She reached. She touched the hem of his robe. And she was healed instantly — she felt it in her body.

And then Jesus stopped the entire procession. *Who touched me?* His disciples thought it was absurd — everyone was touching him, it was a mob. But he kept looking, because he had felt something leave him, and he would not move until he found her. Terrified, she came forward and told him the whole truth in front of everyone.

He did not scold her for breaking the rules. He called her something no one had called her in twelve years. *Daughter,* he said. *Your faith has healed you. Go in peace.*

She is in this book for the woman who has been sick, or ashamed, or shut out for so long that she has stopped expecting to be touched at all. Who has learned to reach for what she needs quietly, from the edge, hoping not

to be noticed. Her story says two things at once: your faith to reach is seen — and the One you reached for will stop everything, in front of everyone, to call you *daughter* out loud.

You are allowed to reach. And you will not go unnamed when you do.

MARY — THE GIRL WHO SAID YES TO THE IMPOSSIBLE

She was young — probably very young — and unmarried, and entirely ordinary, in a small town nobody expected anything from. And an angel came to Mary and told her she was going to carry the Son of God.

We have decorated this story with so much gold leaf that it is easy to forget how terrifying it actually was. An unmarried pregnancy in her world could have gotten her abandoned, disgraced, even stoned. She had every reason to say no, or to argue, or to ask for a different plan. She asked exactly one honest, practical question — *how can this be?* — and then she said the sentence that changed history: *Let it be to me according to your word.*

Yes to the impossible. Yes to a road she could not see the end of. Yes before she had any proof it would be okay.

And later — this is the part I love most — she goes to visit her cousin Elizabeth, and standing there, this teenage girl opens her mouth and *prophesies*. The words that pour out of her, the song we now call the Magnificat, are not soft and demure. They are revolutionary: God has scattered the proud, brought down rulers, lifted up the humble, filled the hungry and sent the rich away empty. This young woman understood that the child she carried was going to turn the whole order of the world upside down, and she sang about it with her whole chest.

Mary is here for the woman being asked to say yes to something bigger than her plans, scarier than her comfort, and impossible to control. Her story does not pretend that yes is easy or safe. It shows what yes makes room for: a courage you did not know you had, and a song you did not know was in you.

LYDIA — THE BUSINESSWOMAN WHO OPENED THE DOOR

By the time we get to the New Testament and the early church spreading across the world, we meet a woman named Lydia, and she is a merchant — a dealer in expensive purple cloth, which means she ran a real business and had real money and real standing in her city.

Lydia heard the message of the Gospel by a river, and she believed, and she was baptized. And then she did something that turns out to be one of the quiet hinges of church history: she opened her home. She insisted — the text says she practically talked them into it — that the traveling apostles stay at her house. Her home became the first church in that entire region of the world. The Gospel came to Europe and put down its first roots in the living room of a working businesswoman.

Nobody asked Lydia to shrink her success to be faithful. Nobody told her that her money or her competence or her independence were problems to be apologized for. She took exactly what she had — a home, resources, a good business, an organizing mind — and she put it in service of something she believed in. Her hospitality was not a lesser gift than the apostles' preaching. It was the ground the whole thing grew in.

Lydia is in this book for the capable, successful woman who has quietly wondered whether her ambition and her faith are supposed to be at war. They are not. Lydia's competence *was* her ministry. Her open door did what a thousand sermons could not. You do not have to choose between being good at what you do and being faithful. Sometimes the most faithful thing is to build something solid — and then throw the doors open.

PRISCILLA — THE WOMAN WHO TAUGHT THE TEACHER

Priscilla is almost always mentioned alongside her husband, Aquila, and here is the small, radical detail that most people read right past: in most of the places the Bible names them together, it names *her first*. In that culture, that ordering was not an accident. It was a signal that she was, in some real way, the more prominent teacher of the two.

They were a couple who worked as tentmakers and traveled with the apostle Paul, and they ran what amounted to a mobile school of the faith. And in one unforgettable scene, a brilliant, educated, eloquent preacher named Apollos comes through town, teaching powerfully — but he has some of it wrong. He does not have the full picture yet.

Priscilla and Aquila hear him. And they do not humiliate him in public. They do not post about his errors. They quietly take him aside, into their home, and they *teach the teacher* — they explain the way of God to him more accurately. And Apollos, to his enormous credit, listens, and becomes one of the most effective voices in the early church, better because a tentmaking woman was willing to correct him with grace.

Priscilla is here for the woman who knows things — really knows them — and has been made to feel she should keep quiet about it. Who has watched someone more credentialed, more platformed, more *male* get it wrong, and wondered whether it was her place to say anything. Priscilla's story is permission. You can know more than the famous person in the room. And the most powerful way to use that is not to embarrass him — it is to take him aside and make him better. That is not smallness. That is the confidence of someone who does not need the credit.

NAOMI — FROM BITTER BACK TO FULL

We end with an older woman, because this whole book has been building toward the long view, and Naomi has the long view.

Naomi lost everything. Her home, her husband, both her sons — all of it gone in a foreign country, leaving her an aging widow with no security and no future. When she finally dragged herself back to her hometown, the women recognized her and called her by name, and she said the most honest, devastating thing: *Do not call me Naomi* — which meant "pleasant." *Call me Mara* — which meant "bitter." *For the Almighty has dealt bitterly with me. I went away full, and the Lord has brought me back empty.*

That is where Naomi's story sits for most of its length. In the empty. In the bitter. And the Bible does not rush her out of it or tell her to cheer up. It lets her name her grief exactly as heavy as it is.

But the story is not finished, and neither is she. Through the loyalty of her daughter-in-law Ruth — whose own story is in the first volume — and a long, patient turning of events Naomi could not see while she was in the dark, her emptiness slowly fills back up. By the end of the book, there is a baby in her lap, a future restored, a life she was certain was over quietly begun again. The women of the town say the line that redeems the whole thing: *He has become to you a restorer of life.*

Naomi is in this book for the woman in the empty season who has started to believe the emptiness is the end of the story. Her life says, gently and without hurrying you: you are allowed to be Mara for a while. You are allowed to name it bitter. But *for a while* is not the same as *forever*, and the God who let her grieve is the same one who, in a time she could not have predicted, filled her arms again.

You went away full and came back empty. Naomi did too. Stay in the story.
Empty is not the last chapter.

YOUR TURN, AGAIN

Eight more women. Look, again, at what they share.

Deborah led without waiting to be allowed. Rahab bet her life on mercy being bigger than her past. Abigail walked into the storm and changed the ending. The bleeding woman reached through the crowd she was forbidden to enter. Mary said yes to the impossible and then *sang* about it. Lydia threw open the doors of everything she had built. Priscilla knew more than the famous man and used it to make him better. And Naomi survived the empty season long enough to have her arms filled again.

Not one of them was waiting to become worthy of her moment. Each of them met the moment as she was — foreign, disreputable, unpermitted, unclean, unmarried, overlooked, or grieving — and did the brave or faithful thing anyway. That is the whole pattern of this book, both volumes of it. Being seen, and then *moving*.

So here is your turn, again. You are somewhere in one of these women's stories right now. You are under Deborah's tree, holding wisdom you keep waiting for someone to authorize. Or you are Abigail, the only steady one in a house full of fools. Or you are Naomi, certain the empty is permanent. Wherever you are, the invitation is the same one all eight of them answered: stop waiting to be worthy, and do the next faithful thing as the woman you already are.

Their stories got rewritten. Not because they became someone else — because they acted, as themselves, at the moment it mattered.

Yours is being written the same way. Right now. In whatever storm you are walking into, or out of.

Go on. It is your turn.

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